AI Movies Flop in Theaters, Even as AI Videos Flood Phones

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Videos made by AI are everywhere in China. A recent report suggests nearly two-thirds of the **microdramas** in China are all made by AI. But people seem to draw a line between free videos on their phones and movies they pay to see in a theater. The fully AI-generated movie Sanxingdui: Future Past flopped at the Chinese **box office**, showing AI still has a hard road ahead in theaters. The film was not a one-click project. Producer Bona says it took two years and a team of 70 to 80 people to make, and it was still being changed a week before it reached theaters. Still, an attendee told the international outlet AFP that the AI falls short of a human-made, **live-action** movie. A 100-minute movie must also pass a **content review** before theaters. The next test is Gossip Goblin's fully AI movie, Gods Don't Give Gifts, opening in U.S. theaters this December. It is the first such movie to receive a **rating** from the MPA, and it hopes to be considered for Best Animated Feature at the Oscars.

Word Treasure

microdramas -- Very short dramas made to watch in small parts, often on a phone.
box office -- The money a movie earns from ticket sales in theaters.
live-action -- A movie filmed with real people and real places instead of animation.
content review -- A check of a movie's content before it is allowed to play in theaters.
rating -- A label that tells audiences what kind of movie it is and who it is suited for.

Background you need

AI videos are videos made with computer programs that can create pictures, movement, and scenes.

A movie theater is different from a phone screen because people pay for a ticket and expect a finished, high-quality film.

Before a movie can play in theaters, it must pass a content review and receive a rating that tells audiences what kind of film it is.

Break it down

WHO: Movie audiences in China, Producer Bona, and Gossip Goblin
WHAT: The fully AI-generated movie Sanxingdui: Future Past flopped at the Chinese box office
WHERE: In theaters in China, with the next test opening in U.S. theaters
WHY: People draw a line between free videos on their phones and movies they pay to see in a theater

Why it matters

It matters when you watch videos on your phone because it shows why a fun free clip and a movie ticket are judged in very different ways.

Test what you remember

1. Where are videos made by AI everywhere, according to the story?

- (A) In China
- (B) In the United States
- (C) In France
- (D) In Japan

2. What share of the microdramas in China does a recent report suggest are all made by AI?

- (A) Nearly one-half
- (B) Nearly all of them
- (C) Nearly one-third
- (D) Nearly two-thirds

3. Which fully AI-generated movie flopped at the Chinese box office?

- (A) A human-made live-action movie
- (B) Sanxingdui: Future Past
- (C) Gods Don't Give Gifts
- (D) An unnamed microdrama

4. What did an attendee tell the international outlet AFP about the AI movie?

- (A) That it was better than human-made movies
- (B) That it was the best animated film of the year
- (C) That the AI falls short of a human-made, live-action movie
- (D) That it took too long to make

5. What must a 100-minute movie pass before theaters?

- (A) A content review
- (B) A fan vote
- (C) An awards contest
- (D) A phone test

6. What is the next test, opening in U.S. theaters this December?

- (A) A human-made live-action movie
- (B) Sanxingdui: Future Past
- (C) A new microdrama series
- (D) Gossip Goblin's fully AI movie, Gods Don't Give Gifts

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: B 4: C 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. An attendee: The AI falls short of a human-made, live-action movie.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):